November 5, 2026 Don’t Just Do Something, Stand There!



I’ve been running dry on these reflection materials of late, which leads me to go looking for some image, quote, quip, thought, book, poem, memory, or social media post that will take root. It’s a bit of a fool’s errand because I get so busy looking that I can’t see, and even when I do get a glimpse of something that intrigues me, I realize it’s not my thought—so it isn’t a reflection at all.

In a recent group conversation about meditation, I suggested that the idea of sitting (standing) quietly and emptying my mind is another snipe hunt for me. In order to release my thoughts, I have to identify and name them, and I need to pause a moment to consider how those thoughts, concerns, ambitions, or hesitations are affecting me—or others. This inventorying process of my brain baggage is a far cry from letting go; it’s much more an exercise of rearranging and repacking all the rocks in my backpack again—or so it seems. Perhaps with more practice and patience, it would work? (Oh great, something new to fret over.)

But I think that maybe I have it wrong. Maybe I shouldn’t be trying to free my mind at all; maybe what I should do, instead, is to free my soul. Maybe I should just stand there, seeing and feeling in awe, wonder, gratitude, and in longing for both the connections that are and those that are not. Maybe, rather than measure and rearrange the rocks I’m carrying, I should just set the pack down for a bit and ask: What are they for, and why am I taking them somewhere—and where? How will I know when and if I’ve arrived? I’ll know the place when I see you there.

Now I know the quote: “For to be free is not merely to cast off one’s chains, but to live in a way that respects and enhances the freedom of others.” — Nelson Mandela

Happy Thinksday